CASE STUDY: The AI-Cloned Residency Scam

What is the Crime? This incident is a sophisticated form of **Phishing and Identity Theft** that utilizes 'Vishing' (Voice Phishing) enhanced by Generative AI. Unlike traditional text-based scams, this involves "Deepfake Audio" to manipulate victims through high-trust social engineering.

How it Typically Happens (Step-by-Step):

1. **Data Harvesting:** The attacker targets a student pursuing a specialized degree, such as CSE with AI and Machine Learning. They gather public information from LinkedIn or university forums to identify students actively seeking internships.
2. **Voice Cloning:** Using a short audio sample of a university official or a known industry mentor (often harvested from a YouTube lecture or webinar), the attacker uses an AI voice-cloning tool to create a near-perfect vocal replica.
3. **The Fraudulent Call:** The student receives an "official" call or WhatsApp voice note. The AI-generated voice, sounding exactly like a trusted professor or department head, informs the student they have been shortlisted for a prestigious, invitation-only AI research residency.
4. **The Payload:** To "secure" the placement and the high-end GPU hardware supposedly provided for the program, the student is directed to a spoofed university portal to deposit a "refundable security fee."
5. **The Theft:** Once the student enters their payment and login credentials on the fake portal, the attacker captures the data and drains the funds.

Who is Usually Targeted? Ambitious students in technical fields are the primary targets. Attackers exploit their professional aspirations and the competitive nature of high-end tech internships to bypass their usual skepticism.

Consequences: The immediate impact includes significant financial loss and the compromise of sensitive academic credentials. Furthermore, it creates a "crisis of trust" within the academic community, making students skeptical of legitimate digital communication and potentially damaging the university's reputation for secure internal messaging.